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EVERYTHING IS INFLAMMATION NOW



ILLUSTRATION: HITESH SONAR

Why has inflammation become the universal language through which the Internet talks about modern life, ageing, food and the body

Sanjukta Sharma

A recent episode of the Oprah Winfrey Podcast revealed a stunning new hypothesis in cancer research. It had nothing to do with artificial intelligence (A.I.) or a new drug’s mechanism. Instead, it was about chronic inflammation.

Winfrey’s guest was Siddhartha Mukherjee, cancer researcher, oncologist and author of the Pulitzer-winning book *The Emperor of All Maladies*. Partway through their conversation, when she asked about the future of cancer treatment, he said, “There are thousands of dormant cancer cells sitting in your body. Then something happens – I call it the sleeping beauty kiss – that wakes them up. We are realising that

that *one something* is chronic inflammation... It really switches around how we think about cancer... If we could test that one particular kind of inflammation, we would have a bio-marker for future cancers that could even be preventive.”

In the longevity era, inflammation is one of the most studied biological phenomena. And increasingly, scientists are discovering evidence that chronic low-level inflammation, or extended activity of immune cells when there’s no immediate threat, is often the cause of disorders, from diabetes and cancer to autoimmune diseases and neurological conditions such as Alzheimer’s.

Just last week, new research published in the *European Journal of Preventive*

Cardiology showed that chronic inflammation increases the risk of heart attack and stroke by 43%. Scientists from MRC Laboratory of Medical Sciences and Imperial College London found that inflammation caused silent structural damage to the heart (thickened walls, smaller chambers and poorer filling) years before symptoms appeared.

Is it any wonder then that inflammation is on everybody’s minds these days? No matter where you look, someone is telling you how to reduce it: from self-help guides to influencers on Instagram breaking down inflammatory foods, inflammation belly, and inflammation face in under three minutes.

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RAGE, REFORM, REPEAT

Mihira Sood’s book traces the landmark cases in the battle for women’s rights and the limits of what they reveal about the ground below



A candlelight vigil in Bhopal against the 2012 Delhi gang rape. (A.M. FARUQUI)

Jhuma Sen

A landmark is visible because the ground around it is flat. Mihira Sood’s *Courting Equality: Landmark Cases in the Battle for Women’s Rights* is, as its subtitle promises, a survey of the tall things, from the Mathura custodial rape case of 1972 to the Uttarakhand Uniform Civil Code. And, as a survey, it is a very good one, written by a feminist lawyer, and also as a feminist lawyer. What happens on the flat ground in between, in the magistrate’s court or family courts, where most women meet the law, is another book, and Sood does not claim to have written it. Her warning that legal reform is no silver bullet recurs through every part of this one.

The strongest tool

The book is arranged in five parts and opens on a tension that Ratna Kapur and Brenda Cossman named 30 years ago in *Subversive Sites*: why do women keep returning to a legal system they have diagnosed, correctly, as patriarchal? Sood’s answer is the practitioner’s – that law is imperfect but perhaps the strongest tool available.

The book tests that faith against judicial archive, from the Mathura case and the open letter of four law teachers to the 1983 amendments; 30 years later, the Verma Committee at the cusp of the Nirbhaya

protests; then the Mahmood Farooqui and Tarun Tejpal acquittals, which showed how quickly a reformed statute is read through unreformed eyes. From this sequence Sood draws the book’s sharpest phrase, “rage, reform, repeat” – outrage changes the law, attention moves on, and the slower and more tedious work of changing the institutions that apply it is left undone. Janet Halley cautioned against governance feminism (feminism walking the corridors of power), and anyone who watched the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita arrive in 2024 with the marital rape exception intact will recognise the cycle.

Sood’s best pages hold two ideas at once. On privacy she is properly ambivalent: Catharine MacKinnon’s warning that privacy has meant a man’s right to be left alone to oppress women sits beside her recognition that *Puttaswamy* and *Joseph Shine* gave women a vocabulary of sexual autonomy that the equality doctrine never supplied. On personal law she follows the ghost of Narasu Appa Mali, the 1951 judgment no bench has overruled and which still places personal law beyond Article 13, through Shah Bano, Shayara Bano, and Sabarimala. Her retelling of Shah Bano, the 75-year-old woman putting her thumb impression to a statement disowning the judgment won in her name, is the book’s most affecting passage, demonstrating the

cost of a landmark to the woman who becomes one. Against the shelf of Flavia Agnes, Nivedita Menon, and Pratiksha Baxi, Sood’s contribution is a single volume that runs the whole arc in prose a general reader can appreciate, which is not a small thing.

View from the ground

My questions concern form rather than content. Katharine Bartlett’s feminist legal method was the ‘woman question’: what has a rule meant for the women who lived under it? A history told through landmark cases asks that question of doctrine, but makes the appellate court its protagonist and reproduces the Supreme Court’s picture of itself as the place where equality is made. Sood anticipates a version of this objection and pre-emptively explains

why there is no chapter on rape in the book: sexual violence is everywhere, so the book is organised by site rather than by offence – a real advance on the casebook. But within each site, the unit of analysis is still the reported judgment.

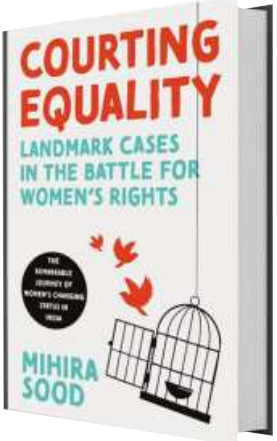
Sood is alert to this. Her repeated insistence that a judgment changes the terms of an argument and not the society in which it has to work is the book’s counterweight. But the structure pulls the narrative upward all the time. It is in the maintenance order that takes years to arrive and execute, for instance, that the gap between promise and delivery becomes visible – a place that a history organised around landmark cases can only visit. The Tejpal trial is the exception that shows the rule: a Goa sessions court put a complainant on trial under a statute that forbade exactly that, but the case is in the book because it became an appellate event. Most trials that go the same way never do.

Second, Mathura was Adivasi and Rameeza Bee was Muslim. Sood defends the 1970s movement’s silence on this: solidarity was the need of the hour. But a Dalit feminist reading, of the kind Sharmila Rege demanded, would treat caste and religion not as facts about the victim but as the mechanism of the violence and its impunity. This is less a criticism than a suggestion for a book that could follow.

Third, the book’s compass points to constitutional morality and to the autonomous individual, whom Sood calls, in the discussion around the Sabarimala case, the smallest minority. Feminist theory has spent 40 years complicating that individual: Jennifer Nedelsky’s relational autonomy and Martha Fineman’s vulnerable subject were responses to a rights-bearer who looked a great deal like a man with a wife at home. On the Uniform Civil Code her distinction between the secular code feminists once demanded and the Uttarakhand statute is exact. I would only add that the state codes now proliferating are as much a question of federal design as content: who legislates the family, and for whom, deserves a chapter of its own.

None of this is a reason not to read *Courting Equality*. It is a reason to read it, as its author intends, as a ledger rather than a triumph. Sood says this is a story everyone should know; she has written the book she meant to write. The flat ground between the landmarks is where the rest of us, including Sood, still practise, and it is a comfort to have so clear a map of the heights.

The reviewer is an advocate practising at the Calcutta High Court and the Supreme Court of India. She writes on gender, family law, and legal history.



Courting Equality: Landmark Cases in the Battle for Women's Rights
Mihira Sood
Juggernaut
₹799



Masculinity and the Booker shortlist

Two former winners are back in the running, alongside a Pulitzer Prize winner and a debut novelist

Radhika Santhanam

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Three of the six books on this year’s Booker Prize shortlist explore masculinity and male sexuality. Interestingly, last year’s Booker Prize winner, David Szalay, also placed modern masculinity at the centre of his story, *Flesh*.

The 2026 shortlist, announced last week, features two previous Booker Prize winners – Marlon James and Douglas Stuart – as well as Pulitzer Prize winner Elizabeth Strout.

James’s *The Disappearing*, described by *The New York Times* as “the novel of the decade, if not the century”, centres on an attack on a group of gay men in late-1980s Jamaica, while they are rehearsing a play. At 640 pages, it is the longest book on the list. James earlier took home the Prize in 2015 for *A Brief History of Seven Killings*.

Stuart, who won the Booker Prize for *Shuggie Bain* in 2020, has been shortlisted for *John of John*, which tells the story of 22-year-old John-Calum Macleod’s homecoming to Scotland’s Isle of Harris. It explores the queer lives of both father and son.

Strout has been nominated for the Prize twice before. Her novel, *The Things We Never Say*, is about Artie Dam, a lonely high school history teacher in Massachusetts. When he finds out a secret, it threatens to upend his world.

The shortlist also includes speculative fiction writer M. John Harrison’s *The End of Everything*, a post-apocalyptic novel about a world in which an unknown entity has altered the course of humanity.

Novelist and poet Luke Kennard’s *Black Bag* draws on a bizarre real-life experiment conducted in the 1960s by Charles Goetzinger, a professor at Oregon State University, and offers a darkly comic critique of higher education as well as an investigation into the crisis of masculinity.

Finally, debut novelist Rebecca Perry’s *May We Feed the King*, which won the Waterstones Debut Fiction Prize, moves between the life of an overlooked medieval king, whose troubled reign puts the future of his kingdom at risk, and a curator who becomes so absorbed in his story that the boundaries between her past and present begin to blur.

The winner of this year’s £50,000 prize will be announced on November 9.

The winner of this year’s £50,000 prize will be announced on November 9.



GETTY IMAGES/ ISTOCK

Tulu or Angika, it is that much more difficult to get past the watchtower. Editors might know or be persuaded to understand the value of a particular text in a particular language, but sales teams are usually reluctant to experiment with anything that doesn’t look like what brought a good inflow the previous year. This is the perennial difficulty. Uncovering the new is the stated goal. But most often, the third book of an already successful writer is what wins a contract.

Though it frequently fails to excite those who can read the original works, translation is a fragile miracle of understanding.

Even today, to me, every translated piece is like a cache of jewels. The opening paragraph of a Sinhala story in the upcoming collection, *5 Stories: Sinhala*, propelled me into something like a *puranic* forest. “Sirinal kattadiya the exorcist tightened the last knot. The Yaka groaned softly, and his head drooped over his neck as he was choked. What he felt at this moment, above all, was an overwhelming sense of sadness and – shame. Then Sirinal kattadiya lifted the Yaka with two fingers and put him into a small bottle.” (‘After Taming the Yaka’ by Prabhat Jayasinghe; translated by Madhubhashini

Disanayaka Ratnayake) Overcoming technical difficulties with what Hugh Kenner calls emotional discipline, translators make the invisible visible. It is a clairvoyant absorption of another world into the familiar. Often, the words blur, they slide, they sit around like granite. Choosing between ‘kingdom’ or ‘realm’, a translator sweats blood. And when a translator has done that, what she writes becomes a work of her own: distinct from the original and yet the same.

To inject a slight warmth of irony, let’s recall Ezra Pound who wrote, “Some translators think of

everything, positively of everything save what the original author was driving at.” This trend continues in carelessly edited translations. What are we to make of “electricity technician” and “he was overstepping himself”? Isn’t it time editors realised that arms are not hands? Clearly, the translator saw no difference at all.

Which brings me to my tribe but more of that in another article.

The writer coordinates a translation project for the Tamil Nadu Textbook and Educational Services Corporation.

EVERYTHING IS INFLAMMATION NOW

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

Turmeric is hyped as a miracle cure, others swear by elimination diets. Then there's the parasite detoxes, ice baths, celery juice resets and monotonous cleanses (where you eat only one food item). The more scientists link inflammation to diseases, the more the wellness industry cashes in by marketing anti-inflammatory products. But take them with a dollop of salt. Often, the advice is fed to us by A.I.-generated doctors, healers and wellness influencers.

Acute and chronic: not the same thing
For most of history, doctors and the public focused on what they could see and feel: red, puffy skin around a wound, pain, fever. "I remember reading an article a few years back about how people with stressful jobs have inflammation, which could lead to illnesses as they age. And I recall closing my eyes and doing a mental body check and noting that 'no, nothing was swollen or achy, so I'm not inflamed'." I was naive and uninformed," says Kajal S. (name changed), a media professional in her 40s, explaining how she didn't know the difference between acute and chronic inflammation.

One evening, a couple of years later, the knuckles in her left hand swelled up, and within a few days she was handed a diagnosis of palindromic rheumatism, a rare type of inflammatory arthritis characterised by sudden, recurring flare-ups and severe joint pain. Her doctor talked her through how consistent stress, bad sleep patterns, and gut issues – and the chronic inflammation it caused (that is devoid of swelling or aches) – played the lead role in her condition. So, what's the difference between acute and chronic inflammation? The former occurs when the body rallies to defend itself against invading microbes or to heal damaged tissue. Capillaries dilate and grow more porous, enabling white blood cells to flood the damaged site. The region swells, which can put pressure

on surrounding nerves, causing pain. Chronic inflammation, however, is often silent and occurs when the immune system is over-stimulated all the time. As researchers are discovering, factors such as poor diet, air pollution, lack of sleep and stress can have a more significant impact on it than previously understood. Over time, in many cases, our immunity can also get so active that it starts attacking our own cells, which is what autoimmune diseases such as rheumatoid arthritis (RA), psoriasis, vasculitis, Hashimoto's disease and others are. Inflammation can also fuel chronic diseases (without autoimmunity), like Alzheimer's and endometriosis.

"Persistent inflammation can contribute to changes in blood vessels and metabolism and is involved in several chronic diseases. The brain is also

connected to these processes," says Dr. Vinaya Bhandari, consultant neurology and neuromuscular disorder specialist from Mumbai's Jaslok Hospital and Research Centre. "Inflammatory signals from the body can interact with the brain and its blood vessels... and continual activation is increasingly recognised as one component of neurological conditions, including neurodegenerative diseases [Alzheimer's, Parkinson's]."

Less inflammation doesn't mean "healthier"
It is easy to see why inflammation is such a perfect social media concept: it is invisible, frightening, scientifically legitimate, associated with many diseases, simple to attach to symptoms, as well as food and products. (Ironically, emerging research shows higher levels of inflammation associated with using social media over face-to-face interaction.)

But detecting chronic inflammation isn't as easy as going to your physician and asking how your immune system is doing. While tests such as C-Reactive Protein (CRP) and Erythrocyte Sedimentation Rate (ESR) can help identify markers of inflammation, for some people such tests just come back negative.

To complicate things further,



normal looks like and when it can become dangerous.

The cancer-chronic inflammation link is something Indian oncologists have begun to consider. "Chronic inflammation can create a biological environment that promotes malignant transformation," explains Dr. Aditya Vidushi, medical oncologist at Faridabad's MIOIC Cancer Care & Research Centre. "A clear example is *H. pylori*, a stomach bacterium that triggers long-term irritation, a

major driver of gastric cancer. Obesity-related low-grade inflammation is linked to higher risks of colorectal, breast, pancreatic, and liver cancers." And the body of science is building. Senthilkumar Rajagopal, associate professor at REVA University in Bengaluru, who has led several research papers on inflammation, says, "South Asian populations may have a distinctive susceptibility to chronic low-grade inflammation arising from the interaction of

genes, visceral adiposity, insulin resistance, environmental exposures and lifestyle factors." The central insight emerging from his work is that targeting molecular interfaces between neuron signalling and inflammatory pathways may offer new strategies.

Maintaining the balance
Experts agree that combining medicine and better lifestyle habits can best prevent flare-ups. But what they



Dr. Shreevidya of Apollo Hospitals; nutritionist Shonali Sabherwal; and gynaecologist Dr. Suganya Venkat. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



prescribe can vary widely, and occasionally be controversial. U.S.-based Mark Hyman, considered the pioneer of Functional Medicine, emphasises in his books that inflammation is the common pathway for all chronic diseases. His recommended solution is an anti-inflammatory diet: omitting sugar, caffeine, beans, dairy, gluten, and processed foods, as well as taking a variety of supplements, including probiotics, fish oil, Vitamins C

and D, and curcumin, a key molecule in turmeric. Meanwhile, in his book *The End of Illness*, American oncologist David Agus prescribes, among other things, not wearing high heels because they inflame the feet and that inflammation could possibly affect vital organs.

The healing journey of Goa-based graphic designer Antima Nahar, 48, diagnosed with rheumatoid arthritis (RA) when she was 35, has taken her to doctors, nutritionists and Ayurvedic retreats. Nahar got the transformative diagnosis after a fall during a monsoon trek on the outskirts of Mumbai. Her doctors told her she would live with pain if she did not take steroids and painkillers all her life. "It started with my toes and fingers, and then became a sharp, pounding pain that kept shifting through different joints in my body. At one point, I couldn't squeeze a toothpaste tube, couldn't open jars or bottles, couldn't hold a phone for long," Nahar says.

After years of naturopathic and Ayurvedic treatments, she found a balance with lowered doses of allopathic treatment combined with naturopathy and lifestyle modifications. "The last decade has been about knowing my body. Flare-ups can be because of food, weather changes, dancing, anything. I started recording everything, thinking through everything I did," Nahar also began making illustrations about her RA journey and is now writing a graphic novel about self-discovery through pain.

Interestingly, chronic inflammatory conditions often manifest differently in men and women. Several studies in the past decade reveal that nearly 70% of all autoimmune disease patients in India are women. In men, it can manifest more as heart disease. Indian men face a cardiovascular death rate (349 per 100,000) that is significantly higher than that of men in Western nations, according to the National Noncommunicable Disease Monitoring Survey (NNMS).

Kochi resident Jai Krishnan Sambasivan, 62, says he wouldn't be able to function well if it were not for steroids. At 42, he was running his own business in Alappuzha, Kerala, when he developed a high fever that lasted months without a diagnosis. Admitted in hospital for over a month, he says he "fit into the category of patients who was clinically well [all tests came back negative], but not well". What finally led to a diagnosis of vasculitis were two high-inflammation markers: his CRP and ESR. Vasculitis is an autoimmune disease that inflames blood vessels, often leading to blockage of capillaries and eventually causing cardiac failure. He has managed to control the disease with Prednesol, a steroid drug, and lifestyle modifications. "But what keeps me alive is not medicine, it is breath control," he believes. "I can say I have mastered it. I have learnt to be fearless."

What you eat matters
Food plays a major role in managing/ preventing inflammation. According to

What to check

Dr. Shreevidya (Apollo Hospitals) highlights tests that can help detect chronic inflammation markers

CRP: "This is what I order first. Your liver makes this protein when inflammation happens. Higher levels suggest inflammation is active."

ESR: "This is a test to measure how fast your red blood cells settle in a tube. If they fall very quickly, there may be inflammation."

Interleukin-6 and TNF-alpha: "These are messengers responsible for inflammatory processes. They are more specific tests but give a clear picture."

Homocysteine and Fibrinogen: "Increased levels indicate the presence of inflammation and heart problems."



In modern life, inflammation has five faces: ultra-processed food, sleep debt, a disturbed gut, a sedentary body, and the one I speak of most – the red mind or a state of constant stimulation

ARPIT BANSAL
ONCOLOGY SURGEON

Delhi-based nutritionist Shonali Sabherwal, a seasonal, pesticide-free, freshly-cooked plant diet is most effective in reducing chronic inflammation. "You need to question staples: the *atta* that you are using, is it a hybrid variety? Do we know what we are really stocking in our kitchens?" Sabherwal's approach, commonly used around the world for conditions such as allergies, autoimmune diseases and other chronic conditions, aligns with Ayurvedic prescriptions for excess *agni* (fire/ inflammation in the body). Dr. Nitin Kochar, a Mumbai-based Ayurvedic practitioner who specialises in cancer and inflammation, says that "depending on the specific *dosha* [*vata*, *pitta* or *kapha*, the Ayurvedic way of categorising the human body's biochemistry], I prescribe fasting, specific plant foods and spices like ginger, cumin, gilo to weaken the fire".

Treatment options
One of the frustrations of treating inflammation is that treatments are so imprecise. Dr. Shreevidya, medical director-preventive health, Apollo Hospitals, says chronic inflammation is usually identified not because someone felt it, but because it surfaced during a preventive health assessment. "Two drivers deserve more attention. One is chronic hidden infection, especially gum disease [untreated periodontitis keeps the whole system inflamed]. The other is air pollution. Long-term exposure to fine particulate matter is consistently associated with higher inflammation," she says. Dr. Divya Gopal, additional director of internal medicine at

Mumbai's Sir H.N. Reliance Foundation Hospital, says people should start with lifestyle changes. "Pain relievers like ibuprofen and naproxen reduce inflammation, but taking them long-term brings risks," says Gopal. "For serious cases, I prescribe newer medications that block inflammation pathways."

As research into inflammation intensifies, new methods are being discovered. Earlier this year, researchers at University College London uncovered a key mechanism that can help the body switch off inflammation and prevent harmful immune cells from building up. Elsewhere, several clinical studies have shown that, independent of weight loss and diabetes, GLP-1 receptor agonists such as Ozempic and Mounjaro can significantly reduce systemic inflammation markers such as CRP and TNF-alpha. There's also talk about non-invasive continuous inflammation monitors, much like glucose monitors.

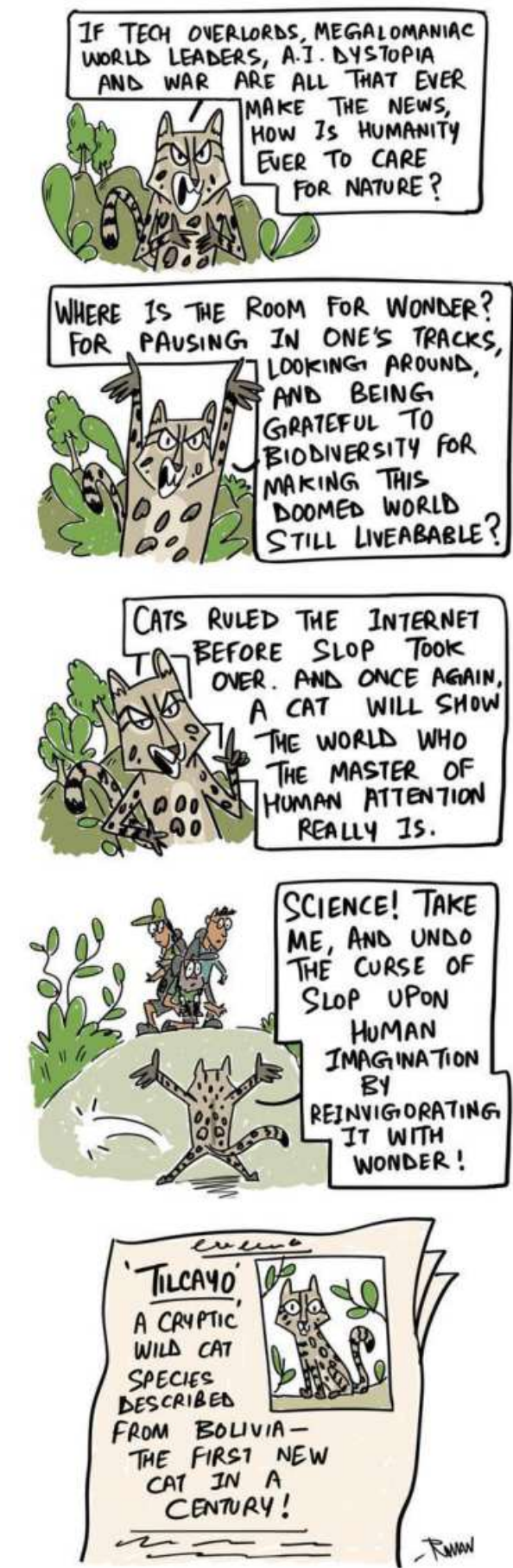
Science may be on the threshold of cures for several diseases that inflammation drives, but it is important to remember the nuance of it all: inflammation is part of our maintenance and repair system. Without inflammation, we can't heal. The challenge is to master the balance between the healing short spells and the stubborn, prolonged simmer that has profound implications for our health.

With inputs from Surya Praphulla Kumar

The Mumbai-based writer and journalist is behind *@the_slow_fix* on Instagram.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Prakash Raj

raandz. I keep getting the same forward. "The government has saved you. UPI till ₹2,000 is free. Sleep well."

Before the slogans start, I want a simple answer. On an ordinary day, how much do you actually scan (to pay)? For tea? An auto? The vegetables? Or the school fee, the hospital bill, the petrol that never stays under ₹2,000 once you fill the tank?

The gift is real. The cut-off is also real. Both can be true at the same time. That is what they are counting on. You will remember only the first sentence.

What the paper actually says
On September 14, the Finance Ministry issued *Gazette S.O. 5067(E)*. (I am writing the number here so nobody tells me later that I imagined it.) Under Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, two things stay free: RuPay debit-card payments of any amount and UPI up to ₹2,000. Banks cannot charge the person sending or the person receiving on those two.

The next day, NPCI (National Payments Corporation of India) put out the rest. From October 15, if you pay a merchant more than ₹2,000

ABOUT THAT 'FREE' UPI

The actor and political activist has some questions about the new UPI fee that has been announced by the Indian government

Five questions for the Prime Minister and the Finance Minister

1. Why are the *kirana* and the middle-class shopping trolley the places you chose to squeeze?
2. RBI sent you about ₹2.87 lakh crore last year. At ₹2,000 crore a year, that surplus alone could have kept the UPI incentive running for about 143 years. Why start a meter on small trade?
3. Banks wrote off ₹16.35 lakh crore in 10 years (₹2.77 lakh crore of that under large industry and services). That write-off pile is more than 800 years of the ₹2,000-crore UPI line you say you will save. Who was rescued, and who is being billed now?

4. Corporate tax incentives from 2019-20 to 2023-24 are about ₹4.53 lakh crore in the Receipt Budget papers. That is over 200 years of free low-value UPI.
5. Ladli Behna scheme in Madhya Pradesh is about ₹23,883 crore this year. Ladki Bahin Yojana in Maharashtra paid about ₹78,700 crore in two years. Uttar Pradesh has put a ₹50,000 offer on the table. For 1 crore women, it is ₹50,000 crore. If money can be found at that scale before a vote, why tell a tea shop the republic can't afford a free QR above ₹2,000?



many times. I believe the circular. But I do not believe the shopkeeper will swallow ₹12 with a smile every time someone pays for the groceries.

Why ₹2,000 sounds like kindness
In August, UPI processed 24.51 billion transactions. That is NPCI's number. The value was ₹29.82 lakh crore. For the full year of 2025-26, it was 24,162 crore transactions and ₹314 lakh crore. Here is the line that sounds good on television. More than 95% of merchant tickets are ₹2,000 or less. Only about 4% of merchant tickets sit above ₹2,000, but those tickets carry about two-thirds of merchant value.

They protected the number of scans, and opened the value. Milk, a cutting *chai*, an auto fare stay free. A sack from the *mandi*, a quarterly school fee, a hospital bill, a month's petrol, that crosses ₹2,000: that is where the meter sits.

In August, Reuters and *India Today* used a rougher cut: about 5% of transactions and 65% of value. That was the proposal stage. After September, NPCI spoke only of person-to-merchant payments. I am keeping both figures so nobody says the numbers were moved in the dark.

First, they built the habit
On November 8, 2016, at 8 p.m., 86% of the cash in circulation in India was declared scrap. After that night, the wallet left the pocket – slowly. In 1989, Section 10A arrived.

On this track, a bank would not take even one extra rupee from you. For seven years, that was true. In the same years, cash itself was made expensive. An annual ATM fee; ₹21 to ₹23 at another bank's machine after the free limit; ₹100 to ₹600 if the minimum balance slipped or the cheque bounced; for an SMS pack; extra pages in the cheque book; branch NEFT; to close an account.

That is the sequence. Bring the people in, make the old road costly, then nail a board on the main gate.

Who actually pays?

On paper, the shop. The circular is polite: the customer app will not cut 0.4%.

Banks are told not to let the merchant pass it on. Write that on a wall in a *mandi* and see how long it lasts. *Kirana* profit margins in this country are often 8% to 12%. That ₹12 has to come from somewhere. MRP rises a little; a cardboard sign goes up; UPI is refused on a large bill. That is pass-through. The meter is on the merchant, the bill is on you.

This is how the government wants the arithmetic to look clean. And save ₹2,000 crore a year on the incentive.

The sentence designed to melt a patriot
Should the system not stand on its own feet? It sounds beautiful, but open the other file as well. The UPI-RuPay incentive was ₹2,196.21 crore in 2025-26. This year's Budget allocates ₹2,000 crore. The Standing Committee and the Department of Financial Services have put the yearly cost of running person-to-merchant UPI near ₹20,000 to ₹20,700 crore. The gap is real. The question is whether the honest way to close it is a meter on the *kirana* bill of ₹2,500, while a lakh sent to a friend for imported shoes stays at zero.

RBI transferred about ₹2.87 lakh crore surplus to the Centre for 2025-26. NPCI is not sitting in a loss. Operating revenue was ₹4,240 crore, and it is still in surplus. Banks wrote off ₹16.35 lakh crore of bad loans from 2014-15 to 2023-24 (Parliament was told that in March 2025). There is room for corporate default at that scale. Breath runs short at a ₹2,000-crore incentive!

This is all I am asking
On October 15, your phone will not deduct 0.4%. That is true. But watch the board above the counter. Watch the MRP. That is where the fee will try to hide. If you run a small shop and your UPI receipts stay under a lakh a month, get the P2PM tag in writing. The circular will not save you on its own.

I am not a banker. I am not an economist on a panel. I am a citizen watching this country being trained, ticket by ticket. If a number here is wrong, correct it in public. If the numbers are right, do not hide behind a free packet of milk.

The gazette number is S.O. 5067(E). The meter starts running October 15, 2026. If you want to ask, ask.

The writer is an actor and political activist.

ALLEGEDLY My personal BRICS goodie bag

Viral unboxing of a different kind, with *dal*, *rajma* and two kilos of jaggery



videos, when I clicked on the drop-down menu, there was no *makhana* from Bihar, coffee powder from Odisha, or *sattu* powder from Gujarat. What would I do with *makhana* anywhere – eat them? Wife keeps crunching away on them at all times of the day and night but I know and you know they are a scam. What does *makhana* contain? It is not rich in protein, it is not rich in fat, it is not rich in vitamins or minerals. Sure, not all foods are consumed for

their nutritional value alone. But *makhana* doesn't even offer you energy. It contains practically no calories, and to top it all, tastes exactly like roasted thermocol. I am positive that, if instead of dry fruits, they had kept bowls of *makhana* on the table when the Iranian President was speaking, our esteemed civil servants wouldn't have been caught gobbling away on camera. Ditto for *sattu* powder,

also a favourite with Wife. The days she decides dinner will be *sattu roti* are the days I feel motivated enough to complete my 16-hour intermittent fasting. It's not just the taste – have any of you seen a real, live *sattu roti* with the naked eye? They have such bad skin compared to a normal *roti* – instead of eating them you feel like taking them out for a *neem* facial.

My 16-item shopping list

Anyway, coming back to my goodies selection, the first three items were a no-brainer: 5 kg of fortified rice kernels, three litres of cooking oil, and 5 kg of Aashirwad *atta*. Given how the prices of essentials have been rising, it was extremely thoughtful to offer grocery options to print journalists, and I salute the government for their kindness. I also selected 2 kg jaggery, 5 packets of *malida*, 2 kg each of *arhar dal*, *moong dal*, *rajma* and *kabuli chana*. Then I picked two 100 gm packets each of *haldi*, *dhania* powder, *jeera* powder, *garam masala* and *Kashmiri la mirch*. Unfortunately, they did not offer *chaat masala*. An oversight that is hard to explain.

This being the month of September, I had been lighting *diyas* from the first day of the month. So lastly, I picked 500 *diyas* (to give away to neighbours for the Grand Deepak Lighting Ceremony on September 17), and 2 kg cotton. That completed my quota of 16 items.

Obviously, it's not possible to fit all of these into a laptop bag. So I changed the default 'goodie bag type' from 'laptop bag' to 'pure tyre gummy sack'. It wasn't easy for me to lug home a sackful of groceries all the way from Bharat Mandapam but as you all know by now, I'm not the complaining type.

G. Sampath, the writer of this satire, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

What nonsense is this?" the old man sitting next to me on the bus told me. "Excuse me?" I replied, dear reader, somewhat confused. I was confused on two counts. First of all, I was listening to something on my earphones, and thought I had misheard the gentleman. And secondly, I had actually heard him, but was somewhat surprised that he had chosen to start the conversation this way.

I mean, there are so many ways to start conversations these days. Did you see the match? Or, did your exam paper leak? Or, have you been disenfranchised through the process of Special Intensive Revision? Or, is your paneer analogue or digital?

So many gentle ways. 'What nonsense is this?' seemed a bit extreme.

But then my 'must help all South Asian people abroad if they seem in crisis' tendency kicked in. And here was this elderly South Asian man on a London bus. Who had spotted some sort of nonsense. Immediately, I whipped out my earphones and offered to help. "Yes, uncle? What happened? Is everything okay?"

Dear reader, deep inside, I knew this was a bad idea. Because this tendency has only ever gotten me into trouble.

Many years ago, I had visited the city of Basel in Switzerland for a conference. After the conference, I was waiting for a tram that would take me to a remote village in the Swiss wilderness, where my company had found a hotel that was cheap enough to meet budgetary constraints. (It was a nice village. There was one restaurant there. And it had one Indian item on the menu. Rice with a side of spring



rolls in a beige-coloured gravy.)

Anyway, I spotted a South Asian family at the tram stop struggling with the map. They were speaking in some variant of Hindi or Urdu. I walked over and said, "Hi friends, can I help you?"

The entire family recoiled from me as if I had offered to personally inject each one of them with Ebola. They clutched their bags to their chests, huddled into a corner, and said, "No thanks! No need! We will manage! No

AGE OF RECLINE

This is the time to sit at home and rest, Uncle said

Sitizenship
/ˈsɪtɪzənʃɪp/
noun

Definition: The deeply held belief that people above a certain age have a sacred duty to sit at home, tend to grandchildren, and avoid all physical, social, or recreational activity, and that any elder who dares to run, socialise, or enjoy life is committing a grave offence against the natural order.

Related Forms:

Sitizen (noun): A person who firmly believes that old age is exclusively for sitting

Sitizenly (adjective): Displaying the values of citizenship

Sitizenship test (noun): The moment an elderly person spots an active elder and is compelled to pass judgment

thanks. No need. Please!" I backed off as assorted Swiss people glared at me.

But, back to the uncle on the bus. "Why do these people do such things?" he said, pointing his chin at a couple that sat across us on the bus. This was a British couple, in their mid-to-late-60s. Both were clearly going to or coming back from some sort of running activity. They were accoutred in sports shirts, sports shorts, and running shoes. And both carried water bottles.

"Did something happen, uncle? Did they say anything?"

No, he said. "Is this the age to run and jump? This is the age to sit at home and rest, no? Why are old people in this country like this?"

Immediately, I understood what is going on. Readers, there is a peculiar phenomenon that occurs when some

old people from our native corner of the world travel to other corners of the world and encounter other elders with different lifestyles.

I don't mean lifestyles from a wealth perspective. But from an activity perspective: running, gymming, socialising in the evening, going to pubs, going on holidays, trekking up mountains, sailing down rivers, and so on. What is the need for all of this, they ask. Is this the age to do gymnastics? What will people think if they see some 65-year-old in a pub at 10 p.m.? It reflects very poorly on the morality of society. They should be sitting at home and taking care of grandchildren or something.

Friends, how do I react to this? Simple. By saying absolutely nothing, nodding along in agreement, and then writing passive aggressive columns about such people in the newspaper.

But yes, I think we very much need a new word for this phenomenon. And that word is: sitizenship.

Example sentence: "My uncle's sitizenship was triggered the moment he spotted one elderly couple trekking down Ben Nevis. "Poor people. Their children have abandoned them on the mountain. Otherwise, what is the need for this showing off?"

Meanwhile, the uncle on the bus got off after two or three stops. It took him merely three minutes to get up, walk to the door, and then step off the bus. But he did it with such social respectability.

Have you noticed sitizenship in your area? Escape.



Sidin Vadukut helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com.

GOREN BRIDGE Opportunity missed

Neither vulnerable. East deals

Bob Jones

American expert Bart Bramley was South, in today's deal. North did well to pass, as no game makes for NorthSouth. In fact, only a heart lead defeats four spades by East-West. It is hard to fault West for not bidding. He had a misfit for partner's suit and, with only 12 high-card points opposite a pre-empt, no real reason to think there

might be a game his way.

Bramley won the opening club lead, an obvious singleton, with dummy's ace. He led a heart to his king and West's ace, and West shifted to a trump. Bramley won in dummy with the nine and ruffed a heart in his hand. He crossed back to dummy with the ace of diamonds and led another heart, this time discarding a club from his hand. West won with the queen, but he had nothing

NORTH		EAST	
♠ 9 8	♥ 10 8 4 3 2	♠ J 10	♥ J 7 6 5
♦ A 9 2	♣ A 4 3	♦ 4	♣ K Q J 10 9 8
WEST		SOUTH	
♠ A Q 7 5 4 3 2	♥ A Q 9	♠ K 6	♥ K
♦ 7 6	♣ 6	♦ K Q J 10 8 5 3	♣ 7 5 2

The bidding:
EAST SOUTH WEST NORTH
3♣ 3♦ All pass

Opening lead: Six of ♣

but spades remaining and he had to give Bramley the king of spades for his ninth trick.

This was nicely played by Bramley, but the defense could have done better. West should unblock his queen of hearts when Bramley ruffs a

heart, and then East must rise with his jack when Bramley leads the third heart from dummy. Fancy footwork by East-West, but it would defeat the contract. Would you have found the winning defense?

QUIZ Easy like Sunday morning

Agents of nature

Berty Ashley

On September 27, 1962, marine biologist Rachel Carson published her book *Silent Spring*. It helped inspire the modern environmental movement and contributed to the growing environmental action that led to the creation of the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency. Which pesticide did Carson warn could have devastating effects on wildlife?

In 1974, Gaura Devi, head of the Mahila Mangal Dal in Reni village, in now-Uttarakhand's Chamoli district, and 27 other women confronted loggers who had come to fell trees. Their action became a defining moment in the Chipko movement. What did the women do to protect the trees?

Cochin International Airport is among India's busiest airports, handling more than 11 million passengers a year. In 2015, it became the world's first airport to operate entirely on renewable energy. Which source does it harness?

KPS is a Glasgow-based firm developing an alternative to conventional wind turbines. They harness wind energy using something we usually think of as a toy. If 'PS' stands for Power Systems, what does 'K' stand for?

The Heliotope is an environmentally friendly house in Germany that is 'PlusEnergy', generating more



A woman protesting tree felling at a Chipko March in Pune. (EMMANUAL YOGINI)

energy than it uses. Inspired by sunflowers, what does the house do to maximise its solar energy?

Icelandic architect Arnhildur Pálmadóttir is pioneering a concept that could turn a naturally occurring material in her country into a sustainable, zero-carbon building material.

What is this material that is formed deep in the Earth's mantle?

The Zero Emission Multiple Unit (ZEMU), built by the ICF (Integral Coach Factory), Chennai, began operating in July 2026 on the Jind-Sonipat route in Haryana. It uses oxygen from the air and a

gas stored onboard to generate electricity, with water and heat as by-products. What gas powers the train?

Saltwater Brewery in Florida became known for replacing plastic six-pack rings with an edible, compostable alternative. What waste products from the brewing process did it use to make the rings?

The Dobson Unit (DU) is used to measure the concentration of a certain gas in the atmosphere. Global average levels are around 300 DU, while over Antarctica they fell to around 100 DU during periods of severe depletion between the 1980s and 1990s. This depletion was linked to concerns about increased skin-cancer risk. What gas does the DU measure?

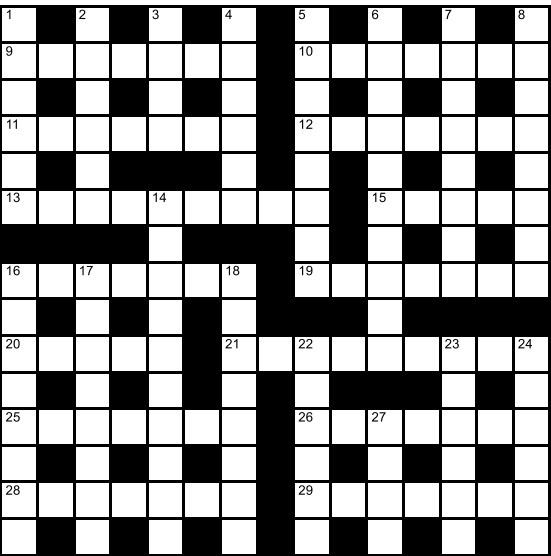
In the book *Agents of Nature* by Komal Thakur and Bhavna Tanwani, children learn about a hidden underground network of fungi that connects plants and helps move nutrients through forests. Known as the 'WWW', what does it stand for?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

- 1. DDT
- 2. Hugged the trees
- 3. Solar energy
- 4. Kite
- 5. Potatoes to follow the sun
- 6. Lava
- 7. Hydrogen
- 8. Barley and wheat
- 9. Ozone
- 10. Wood Wide Web

Answers

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 75 (Set by Afterdark)



Across

- 9 How, in the absence of leader, NGO takes an extreme legal action that harms itself (3,4)
- 10 In any environs a cat can make-up (7)
- 11 Girl has argument with boy and a middle-age planter, perhaps (7)
- 12 Deep rumble across lake, banks of Tahoe getting empty (7)
- 13 Painting outside tunnel features puma essentially in a place full of trees and plants (9)
- 15 Thanks to say, Aishwarya moving to the front to present an accompaniment (5)
- 16 About flowers' emergence (7)
- 19 California pub has stranger in show (7)
- 20 Earthenware for sprite during duty frequently (5)
- 21 Two small sips frequently after bar to return to most effective range (5,4)
- 25 At college in university campus, six learners found discourteous (7)
- 26 Scarf used as silencer (7)
- 28 Frequently orders meals last and distributes again (7)
- 29 Certain to carry some weight on bare head (7)

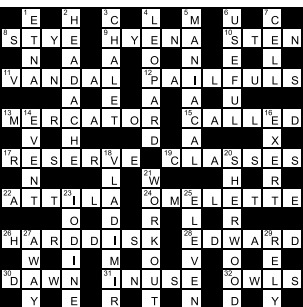
Down

- 1 Record on American soldier is placed on a gallery (6)
- 2 Specialist doctor owns nothing at Bury (6)
- 3 Drove back carrying black explosive (4)
- 4 Fiery boxer facing heartless Goliath at Thailand (6)
- 5 Global pressure and half of them in crisis

basically (8)

- 6 Manipulative woman with anger uses club on mammal (7,3)
- 7 Innkeeper is furious; deli's facade is missing here in the centre (8)
- 8 Classify sect at Puducherry outskirts for resettling (8)
- 14 In comparison, say sister's landlady is heartless (10)
- 16 Say, a conservative recycles gold and uranium, hard without a shred of honesty (3,5)
- 17 Beam at the ends collapses castle (8)
- 18 Things that are dreamt by wife and husband; having a son, basically loved first (4,4)
- 22 Half of open university ultimately end with hatred (6)
- 23 At the core, pupils allege pauper has an accumulation (6)
- 24 Adding 50% of vegetable's crucial for power, say (6)
- 27 Celebration with daughter at capital (4)

SOLUTION NO. 74



Shelley Walia
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The steamer moves quietly out of the historic Rütli Meadow on Lake Lucerne into waters of an unbelievable turquoise, a colour that can only be imagined. As the wind comes off the Rigi in long clean sweeps and the villages on either shore recede into their Alpine stillness, the noise of the ordinary world falls away. And I begin to palpably feel the presence of silence and the spirit of the great writers who had come to these waters before me.

It's been many days since I came to its shores. It was not for anything else but a pilgrimage, an act of homage to the writers and musicians who shaped the way I see and hear and think. I came to T.S. Eliot young, as so many of my generation did, and spent years inside *The Waste Land*, that great broken monument to a civilisation in crisis, assembled from fragments of everything Eliot had loved and mourned: "These fragments I have shored against my ruins." What I did not fully understand until I stood on the deck of the steamer, with the Alps closing in on all sides, was how much of *The Waste Land* is Wagnerian, and how deeply Eliot had absorbed the music that was born on these very shores.

The Rhine daughters from *Götterdämmerung* move through the poem like waterborne ghosts. Wagner, composing those obsessions into music at Tribschen, just a few kilometres along this same shore where I spent some blissful days, had no idea that a young American poet would one day turn them into the defining poem of the modern age. *Frisch weht der wind* – the fresh wind blows – sounds across Eliot's opening pages, a fragment of *Tristan und Isolde* carrying with it all the weight of doomed love and irrecoverable loss. Eliot took Wagner's obsessions of desire, dissolution, and the yearning for transcendence, and projected them through the traumatised landscape of the 20th century.

Travel by imagination

Just off the shore near Brunnen, the steamer passes a small rocky island called the Schillerstein – Schiller's Rock – named after Friedrich Schiller, the German poet and dramatist who wrote *Wilhelm Tell*, that blazing celebration of Swiss freedom and resistance to tyranny. The Swiss adopted his vision as their own national myth, though Schiller never came here. He never crossed this lake, never felt this wind blowing through his hair as I did. He conjured the Rütli meadow, the mountains, the lake itself, entirely from imagination, so ardently that it possessed his very being, and a rock was named for him on waters he never crossed. Imagination, it turns out, is the more reliable form of travel.

They came, these writers and composers and visionaries, not as tourists but as runaways from political tyranny and personal adversity. The overpowering conventions of the societies that had



Nourishing the soul Lake Lucerne set against the Alps in Switzerland. (FILE PHOTO)

formed them had to be shed. Wagner arrived at Tribschen in exile, banned from his homeland, his great cycle of music dramas still unfinished. Tolstoy came as a young man barely formed, still searching for the moral framework that would consume his later life. Hesse came broken by the First World War, by a collapsing marriage and a nervous crisis that had brought him to the edge of a breakdown. Mary Shelley came at 18, though to Lake Geneva, in the aftermath of personal tragedy. What was common among them was a landscape so overwhelming in its beauty that it demanded an equivalent seriousness in return.

Wagner at Tribschen composed with a fury and a tenderness that coexist nowhere else so starkly as in the *Siegfried Idyll*, placed as it is on a staircase at dawn for the woman he loved – the epitome of human grandiosity. Schiller, who never left his study, summoned from pure imagination a Switzerland so vivid and so morally alive that it outlasted every political upheaval that followed. Tolstoy, shaken to his core by the indifference of wealthy hotel guests to a street musician playing outside their windows, sat down and wrote of

Lucerne with an anger so grief-stricken that *A Ballad of Hotel Schweizerhof* became a lasting wound in his mind. And Hesse, walking the hills above the lake day after day, found in the Swiss light a bridge between the European tradition that had formed him and the Eastern philosophy toward which his broken spirit was reaching.

Solemnity and honesty

The lake asked the same thing of each of them: solemnity and honesty. Sitting on the upper deck of the ferry, as Rütli recedes, the cool wind off the Rigi touches something in me too. The villages pass in their stillness, and the ghosts arrive together with Eliot carrying Wagner, Wagner haunting Eliot, Schiller's rock rising from the water though its namesake never touched it.

What was first imagined on these waters indeed becomes a palpable experience of what I have so much loved and believed in all my life. To my mind, this is what a pilgrimage feels like. Not the arrival at a shrine, but the crossing, the in-between suspension over turquoise water, in the company of the dead who remain so stubbornly alive.

FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

▼
Cover story
Food safety cannot depend on the consumer identifying adulteration after purchase. ('Who's watching what we eat?' Sept. 20) The long chain from producer to retailer needs stronger monitoring. Regular inspections, lab testing, traceability and prompt action against violations can make a difference. **Abbharna Barathi**
▼
Not everyone can afford organic food. The FSSAI must test every packaged food and ban it if found to be adulterated. The authority should also bring the manufacturers of such adulterated products to book. **K. Pradeep**
▼
Tragedy continues
The various dimensions of the Palestinian suffering at the hands of Israeli settlers in the West Bank, and their acts of resistance have not become adequately known to the wider world. ('Small acts of resistance'; Sept. 20) This book could help fill that gap. **Kosaraju Chandramouli**
▼
Strike at the root
Enforcement of food safety should move beyond occasional retail inspections. ('High risk, higher safety'; Sept. 20) Authorities must identify vulnerable points in supply chains and intensify testing of milk, spices, oils and other high-risk products. **M. Barathi**
▼
Diversity is the name
The chutney is a small but vivid record of India's geography and culinary traditions rather than a mere accompaniment to a meal. ('We need a chutney map'; Sept. 20) Across linguistic and cultural boundaries, it acquires different identities. A chutney map would truly reflect Indian culinary diversity. **Umaraj Menon**
▼
Shape of devotion
Devdutt Pattanaik beautifully illustrates how Krishna is celebrated and worshipped in different forms across the country. ('Krishna's many forms'; Sept. 20) Various factors, from geography and history to economy, culture, and caste have influenced and shaped this practice over the years. As the author mentions, god was never singular or fixed, or an absolute idea imposed from above. **Vasam Sravanthi**

▼
Valuable skillset
The celebration of craftsmanship shows that handmade objects need not remain confined to nostalgia. ('The future of handmade'; Sept. 20) Good exhibition design can reveal the skill and knowledge embedded in craft. India should invest in artisan training, market access and documentation of traditional techniques. **P.S. Harishmitha**
▼
All about Chettinad
The life and times of Chettinad's Nagarathar community encompass plenty of unique aspects, including their architecture and the culinary expertise of the women. ('Inheriting Chettinad'; Sept. 20) Visalakshi Ramaswamy has painstakingly curated all that is unique about the community's culture and offered it to the world. **C.V. Aravind**



MORE ON THE WEB
www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

▼
Longevity without an expiry date
The human body didn't sign any terminal contract; the cap is in our heads, not in our cells **Thomas Paul**

Mindfulness in the mountains
Confronted by mortality, it became the default state of mind **Abhishek Pant**

When convenience becomes dependence
The machine has become our researcher, secretary, travel agent, editor, and sounding board **Priyan R. Naik**

Reclaiming the lost art of paying attention
Start with small acts such as not wearing earbuds while walking or using your phone during study and mealtimes **Abhimanyu K. Mishra**

Contributions of up to a length of 700 words may be e-mailed to: openpage@thehindu.co.in Please provide the postal address and a brief background of the writer. The mail must certify that it is original writing, exclusive to this page. The Hindu views plagiarism as a serious offence. Given the large volume of submissions, we regret that we are unable to acknowledge receipt or entertain queries about submissions. If a piece is not published for eight weeks please consider that it is not being used. The publication of a piece on this page is not to be considered an endorsement by The Hindu of the views contained therein.

Speed humps are a necessary evil

Aakash Bajpai
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Every evening, when I go for a walk, I face vehicles encroaching on the footpath at specific spots with speed-breakers. Drivers avoid them and take the footpath. Occasionally, some motorcyclists even honk at me to move aside and let them pass through.

One may fail to rationalise the very existence of speed-breakers. Motorists dislike them for the discomfort they cause while driving. They cause wear and tear to the vehicles when they are not built to standards. People with health issues and those pregnant see them as devils. Pedestrians hate them equally for ruining their peaceful walk when the vehicles start crossing over the footpath. Bicyclists often wish they had a separate lane free of all such nuisances. But speed-breakers are supposed to augment safety. Well, in theory, yes. Practically, it is debatable.

A parliamentary reply presents some dated but noteworthy data to reflect upon. In the year 2014, as many as 11,008 road accidents occurred due to speed-breakers, killing 3,633 persons and injuring 9,428. A year later, 11,084 road accidents were attributable to speed-breakers, causing 3,409 deaths and injuring 9,764 people.

Empirical studies have found that vehicles consume significantly more fuel if speed-breakers are present because of the deceleration and the acceleration that follow.

Speed-breakers might have a utility in certain areas such as parking lots, schools, and hospitals. However, their omnipresence fuels annoyance. Principles of design thinking must be applied to achieve the positives that the speed-breakers are supposed to offer. Instead of making vehicles slow down at regular intervals, make it taxing to accelerate in certain circumstances, which is possible through modern technology.

Today, while researchers are exploring ways of generating energy from speed-breakers, one waits for that invention that serves as a viable alternative to those bumps.

Chanchala Borah
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A few days ago, a college student contacted me. He assumed I could give him advice because I sound wiser than I actually am. Naturally, I basked in the glory and expected my worldly experience to churn out pearls of wisdom to guide this lost soul towards the right path.

His problem was that with every new article he read, video he watched or piece of news he came across, his aim in life kept changing.

For example, he would read about an inspiring IAS officer and decide that he wanted to become an IAS officer. Then he would get inspired by the quality of the video itself and decide that he wanted to become a content creator. After reading a few articles, he now wanted to become a writer.

He expected advice about whether or not he was overthinking and if there was a way out.

Unfortunately, my first thought was: "Hey, I have the same problem. Do I know what to do?" This was an unfortunate discovery.

The problem with giving advice is that people assume you have solved the problem you are advising them about. Nobody wants to hear career advice from someone who still occasionally stares at job portals, wondering whether the corporate world is really their calling or whether they should abandon everything and open a bakery.

I thought about his problem. He wanted to do everything and nothing at the same time. This sounded ridiculous.

Then I realised most

Young or old, making a choice is confusing

The mind can behave like a toddler in a toy shop, flitting from one interest to another



▼
At a crossroads A student changes his mind every week, and everyone worries about him. An adult changes jobs every three years, and he is called dynamic. (GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO)

adults are doing the same thing.

We have become better at hiding it. We call the young person's confusion a lack of direction. We call the older person's confusion a career transition.

A college student changes his mind every week, and everyone worries about his future. An adult changes career every three years, and everyone calls him dynamic.

The real problem is not that young people have too many interests. The problem is that they have not yet learned the sophisticated adult technique of pretending to have one.

Not stopping at one We tell young people to follow their passion as though passion is a GPS

location. Just follow it. It will lead you somewhere. Nobody tells them that passion can behave like a toddler in a toy shop. Today, it wants to be a doctor. Tomorrow, it wants to be police. The day after that, it wants to be an animator. By Friday, it has watched three videos about artificial intelligence and wants to build a start-up. And then, after seeing a successful director talk about movies for two hours in the morning, it wants to be a filmmaker. Perhaps what this



We don't always discover what we want. Sometimes we eliminate what we don't want

(Clockwise from below) Installation view of the 2023 exhibition *Textile Masters to the World: The global desire for Indian cloth*; Peter Lee; *baba* (Peranakan man) in a *sarong kebaya*; portrait of businessman Oei Tiong Ha; a *sarong kebaya* from Lee's parents' collection; and NUS Baba House. (JOHAN SATHYA DAS, GETTY IMAGES, AND COURTESY PERANAKAN MUSEUM AND ASIAN CIVILISATIONS MUSEUM)



Jagdish Mittal from Hyderabad. He admits to being biased towards chintz and *kalamkari*. “I have been collecting *kalamkaris* from various world markets, from Japan to Thailand, Indonesia, Nepal, Iran, the Netherlands and even America. It is fascinating how versatile and creative the artisans were to produce patterns in demand in specific markets.” An example is the production of the two-sided *kalamkari* (called *kain chit dua muka* or chintz with two faces) for Southeast Asian islands. “Because the textiles were often draped in a way that revealed both sides, it was necessary to draw and dye the pattern on two sides of the cloth,” says Lee, who has two published essays on chintz.

For him, collecting is not to be “greedy or self-indulgent”, but for a bigger purpose. “I am open to all kinds of people [with an interest in photography and textiles] coming over to my home to see my collection. I encourage them to touch and smell old textiles. They all have different feels and scents; this is something AI can never reproduce.”

Hybridity has always had his heart. Objects without a definitive identity, which historians would use to typify a culture, period or community, and thus left out of their studies. The transient culture of Asian ports was ideal for such objects. “For example, in the Indonesian market *kalamkari* does not have the same national stature as indigenous textiles like Javanese *batiks*. But culturally, they are integral to the material culture of the islands,” he says. “The art and culture of these communities that are hybrid celebrate human enterprise at its most unbridled and egalitarian. And the spirit of unabashed experimentation, creative improvisation, and non-conformist expression resonate with contemporary global art and culture.” Lee is now readying for an exhibition opening at the end of October at the Peranakan Museum in Singapore. “Titled *Exceptional/Everyday: New Acquisitions, New Perspectives*, it will feature 14 objects, both exceptional and everyday, that reshape what we think of Peranakan heritage,” he concludes.

The writer is a cultural activist, philanthropist, and founder of Prakriti Foundation.

CHECKS, CHINTZ AND CULTURAL CROSSINGS

Singaporean collector and scholar Peter Lee talks about his favourite Indian textiles and how culture is shaped by merchants and multicultural ports

Ranvir Shah

Peter Lee is a man who wears many hats. The Singaporean collector, of Peranakan Chinese ancestry, is an independent scholar, researcher and curator. He is also an Indophile who believes that the “love of checks” unites Peranakan and South Indian textile collectors. “My father and grandfather wore what we call Pulicat sarongs at home [which can be traced to the 17th-century port town of Tamil Nadu]. They are so much a part of my memories of everyday life,” says Lee, who was in Karaikudi a few days ago to participate in the annual Chettinad Heritage and Cultural Festival.

The experience, he shares, was inspiring. “Coming from an

old community of traders with regional networks, Chettinad heritage really resonated [with me]. Art history is largely still dominated by state narratives and the works of intellectual elites. Chettinad history and material culture, like those of the Peranakan, Parsi and Armenian trading communities, are facets that contour our understanding of the past in diverse ways.”

Decoding the kebaya

Lee has traced his Peranakan genealogy back nine generations, and learnt much about his community's culture. The *kebaya*, an open jacket worn by women, was of particular interest. “I always thought it was quintessentially Peranakan but the deeper I got into it [for his 2014 book *Sarong Kebaya*], the complexities of the cultural entanglements of

its past became more apparent,” he says, explaining how many cultures have influenced its design. “We have imposed a fixed sense of race and identity on dress, and I found that Peranakan fashion can help us rethink that. Because the community resided in multicultural port cities, they did not comply with sumptuary dress codes. It spoke to me about hybridity, and made me question every object and culture and how things are pieced together.”

The Peranakan community is an umbrella description for mixed families in Southeast Asia. “Race, identity and nationality are all modern concepts,” says Lee. “The past was more organic. When these migrant merchants came, they would find local partners/spouses, which led to hybrid rituals, spiritual

practices and customs.”

His interest in all things Peranakan led to his role as founding curator of the NUS (National University of Singapore) Baba House, a 19th-century townhouse belonging to a wealthy stevedore family. Lee calls his involvement serendipitous: he'd met the current owner of the house, who wished to preserve his history, at the same time his aunt Agnes Tan wanted to find a project that she could donate to – in memory of her late father Tun Tan Cheng Lock, a Peranakan businessman and political leader. Lee brought them together and now Baba House is a one-of-its-kind museum with objects and interiors intact from 1929, when the house was built.

“Historical house museums can give a multi-sensory understanding of the past,” he explains. “The subliminal effect of seeing, smelling and even feeling things is something not achievable in a standard museum.” The house, which is currently being restored, is set to open next year. “The Tun Tan Cheng Lock Trust has contributed an endowment to NUS that will ensure there will be funds for staffing, programming, repairs and maintenance.”

Family influence

Lee's collection spans Tamil and Indian textiles, Peranakan treasures, old photographs and objects that tell stories of trade,



Scan the QR code to watch a rapid fire with Peter Lee



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PETER LEE
Collector, scholar

migration and cultural exchange across Asia. He credits his interest to three mentors: his father, mother and paternal uncle.

He has often talked about his father who used to take him to bookstores as a child and encouraged him to buy one book each visit. But his mother was a connoisseur of all things beautiful. “An instinctive collector”, her different interests became collections, from porcelain and furniture to textiles. She had one of the finest stocks of *sarong kebayas* sets, ornamented with print, painting and embroidery.

His paternal uncle was an architect and architectural historian, and growing up, Lee had access to his library and its huge cabinets stacked with old maps and 19th-century photographs of cityscapes.

The heart of hybridity

Lee has travelled extensively in India and learnt from scholars, including the late collector

Not so long ago, on an oppressively hot and humid day in July, I walked into the cancer clinic. This was my second visit. On the first, I had come in after being referred by my physician because I had found something ‘suspicious’ in one of my breasts.

I stepped into the cool air-conditioned room, the nausea and anxiety of uncertainty rising in me. The waiting room was painted the usual ‘hospital lemon’ and smelt of worry and unease. It was a small room and only a few chairs were occupied. I took a seat next to a lady.

I sat scrolling through my phone as I waited for my name to be called. I had tried reading for a while to distract myself, but had given up after going over the first sentence again and again. I looked at a website for handbags. I had been admiring a beautiful handmade leather handbag for months now, but had always come up with reasons to not buy it. It came in two colours, tan and black, and had a shiny gold lock on the front, like a statement that whatever you placed inside would remain safe.

I must have been fidgeting when the woman seated next to me said, ‘Definitely the tan one.’ She had thin tubes attached to her wrists. She was in a hospital gown but she didn't look unwell.

She said her name was Fiona. She asked me why I was there, ‘If it's not too impertinent of me to ask.’ I explained, and asked her



ILLUSTRATION: ZAINAB TAMBAWALLA

A LITTLE LIFE

The women who held me

When Phuphee and a bag named Fiona offered hope

about why she was there.

She replied, ‘The bastard's everywhere,’ to which I must have reacted so visibly that she reached out to touch my arm and said, ‘Oh, don't worry, I am alright. I don't really feel anything as yet.’

She seemed to register my hesitation of not knowing what to say, so she carried on speaking for which I was grateful.

She wasn't ‘old old,’ she said. Her children were all grown up, but she would have loved to watch them get married and have babies. ‘I was

never the sentimental type,’ she said wistfully, ‘but I do wish I could have been around to see the grand children.’

‘Is there nothing that can be done?’ I asked.

‘Well, they say removing them might buy me a bit more time,’ she replied, pointing to her chest, ‘but during that time I might just be chained to my bed. I don't know if it's worth it. I think I might just prefer to go in my own bed at home, surrounded by people I know and love. I don't see the point

of inflicting more misery on myself.’

She was about to say something when the nurse came in and called her name. She gathered her stuff and, before disappearing into the corridor, she whispered, ‘If you ever buy the tan one, name it in my honour. Call it ‘the Fiona’.’

After a short time, my name was called and I was taken in. As I lay on the table, thoughts flew in from every direction. I thought of Fiona and her hopes. I thought about my children and their smiling faces. I thought about how they ran to me

in happiness and in sorrow. I remembered being a child and running to Phuphee in the same way and I wept quietly, without moving, so as not to disturb the precise site from where the biopsy had to be taken.

I prayed, silently, while a long needle tore a tiny bit of my flesh. I prayed that I made my children feel just as safe as Phuphee had made me feel and that they felt just as loved. One of the nurses who was holding my hand, dabbed a tissue against my cheek and asked if I was in pain.

I said I wasn't really in any pain but that something was digging into my ribcage.

She replied it was probably because of the way the table was designed, to which the doctor who was doing the biopsy added, ‘Yes, that's because it was designed by a man,’ in a grumpy tone. Her remark was met with peals of laughter and it felt, for a split second, more like a soiree and not a medical procedure.

Later at home as I was resting, Phuphee rang.

‘Myoan shoosh [my lungs], are you alright? I am just making some *paatchi rass* [soup made from slow cooking lambs' feet] for you. I will bring it over soon.’ I told her I was okay and then I told her about Fiona.

‘Waenyij ches derr [her liver is strong – a reference for someone who has courage],’ she replied and told me to get some rest.

Later that evening, as Phuphee spooned the soup into my mouth, I

told her I was afraid of what the results would bring. She put her hand in her *pheran* pocket and took out a small red pouch.

‘Here, I made this for you. It is from a suit from my *wardhan* [wedding trousseau].’

It was made from deep red silk, the sheen still present though time had tried its best. She had sewn little flowers on it in delicate white thread. It smelt faintly of cardamoms and time. On the inside, she had hand-embroidered the name ‘Fiona’, in Urdu.

‘Myoan jaan [my life], I know you are terrified,’ she whispered as she moved closer to me.

I leaned into her body, my frame now bigger than hers, but she held her ground and me in place as she had always done. I wept, with great big heaving sobs as I stood on the precipice of this mountain not knowing what tomorrow would bring, not even sure how many tomorrows were left, but absolutely certain of her love and her steadfastness in the face of everything life had thrown at me.

‘Bae ches yeti, bae ches yeti, bae ches yeti [I am here, I am here, I am here],’ she whispered, as she held me, chanting the words like a prayer, over and over again, until I fell asleep.



Saba Mahjoor, a Kashmiri living in England, spends her scant free time contemplating life's vagaries.